

The Evidence Toolkit

Twenty conversations in fourteen days, recorded so that somebody who was not there can check them. This is the requirement most founders think they have already met.

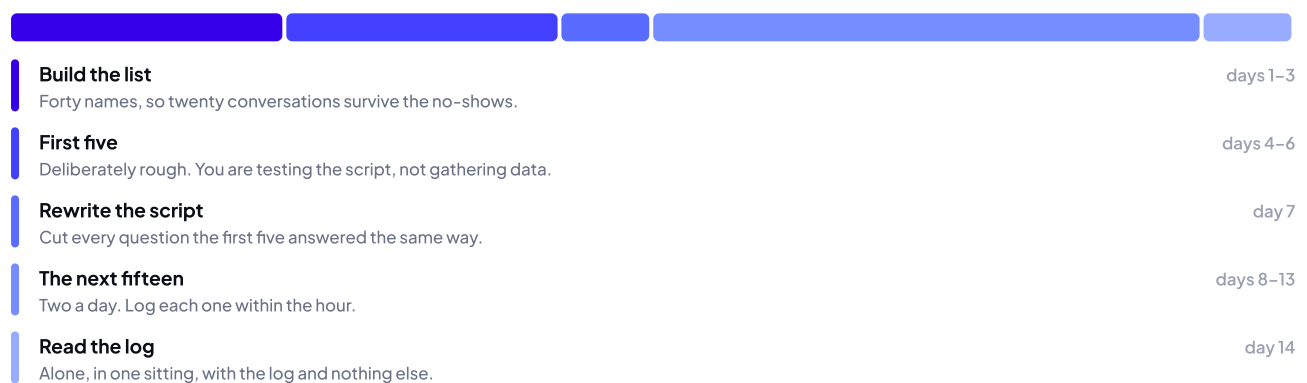


A conversation you cannot count is not evidence.

Most founders have already had these conversations. What they have not done is count them, date them, record who said what, and keep the record somewhere a stranger could read it. That difference is the entire requirement.

Twenty is not a magic number and it is not statistically significant. It is the point at which you stop hearing new things, which is the only thing you are listening for. Fourteen days is not a deadline for its own sake either: spread these over three months and the early conversations describe a different world from the late ones, and you cannot compare them.

FOURTEEN DAYS



Fourteen days, five phases. The rewrite on day seven is not optional. A script that survives twenty conversations unchanged was not asking anything that could have surprised you.

Before you start

Decide now what result would make you stop. Write it down. A founder who has not decided in advance what disconfirmation looks like will not recognise it when twenty people hand it to them.

Forty names to get twenty conversations

Half of the people who agree will not show up, and that is normal rather than a sign of anything. Build the list at twice the size you need and the fourteen days survive contact with reality.

STAGE



Plan for this shape rather than being surprised by it. The drop between agreed and happened is almost entirely scheduling.

The recruiting funnel. The numbers are a planning assumption, not a measurement — track your own and you will know your real ratio by the second week.

Where the names come from, in order of usefulness

- 01 People you have already watched have the problem**
Colleagues, family, the shop you buy from. You are not looking for strangers — you are looking for accuracy.
- 02 One degree out, through someone who will introduce you**
An introduction converts several times better than a cold message and costs you one favour.
- 03 Where the problem is already being discussed**
A Facebook group, a WhatsApp group, a building, a market, a queue. People complaining about something are pre-qualified.
- 04 Cold outreach, last**
It works, but the response rate will make your fourteen days slip. Use it to top up, not to start.

What to say when you ask

“I am trying to understand how [specific situation] actually works. I am not selling anything and I am not going to ask you to sign up to anything. Twenty minutes, this week?” — and then honour both promises exactly. Selling in a research call costs you the next introduction.

Ask about the past, never about the future

People are generous and they want to help, which makes them unreliable about what they would do. They are far more reliable about what they did. Every question below is built to keep the conversation in the past tense, where the answers are made of memory rather than imagination.

SAY	NEVER SAY
Tell me about the last time that happened.	Would you use something that did this?
What did you do about it?	Do you think this is a good idea?
What did that cost you — money, or hours?	How much would you pay for it?
Who else did you talk to about it?	Would you recommend it to a friend?
What did you try before that?	Does that sound useful to you?

The right-hand column is not merely useless. It is actively misleading, because a yes costs the person nothing and buys them a pleasant end to the conversation. Every founder who has been told twenty times that their idea is great and then launched to silence asked the questions on the right.

The script card

PRINT ONE PER CONVERSATION

Five questions, in this order. Do not add a sixth until you have run five conversations and found something the five do not reach.

1. Tell me about the last time [the situation] happened.

Then stop talking. The silence after this question is where the value is.

2. What did you do about it?

3. What did that cost you?

Push for a number — pounds, or hours. “A lot” is not an answer.

4. What had you tried before that?

5. Who else has this problem, and could you introduce me?

This question is how the list of forty keeps growing.

The rule that makes the rest work

Do not describe your idea until the person has finished describing their problem. The moment they know what you are building, every subsequent answer is shaped to be kind to you. If you must describe it, do it in the last two minutes, and mark the log to say you did.

One row per conversation, filled in within the hour

The log is the deliverable. The conversations are not evidence until they are written down in a form somebody else could audit — which is exactly what a programme, a judge or an investor is checking when they ask how you know.

COLUMN	WHAT GOES IN IT	WHY IT IS THERE
#	1 to 20	So the count is a count and not an impression.
Date	The date of the conversation	Evidence has an age. Three months old is history.
Who	Name or initials, and what they do	Makes the row checkable.
Source	How you reached them	Tells you which recruiting channel actually worked.
Problem raised unprompted?	Yes or no	The single most predictive column on the sheet.
Last occurrence	When it last happened to them	Separates a live problem from a remembered one.
Cost	Money or hours, as stated	Turns severity into something comparable.
Current workaround	What they do today	Your real competitor, in their words.
Quote	One sentence, verbatim	The only thing that will survive into your application.
Would they talk again?	Yes or no	Your follow-up list, and your verification list.

Evidence log · rows 1–5

COPY THIS PAGE FOUR TIMES

Fill this in within an hour of each conversation. A log written at the end of the week is a reconstruction, and reconstructions flatter the founder.

1. Date · Who · Unprompted? · Cost · Workaround

Quote

2. Date · Who · Unprompted? · Cost · Workaround

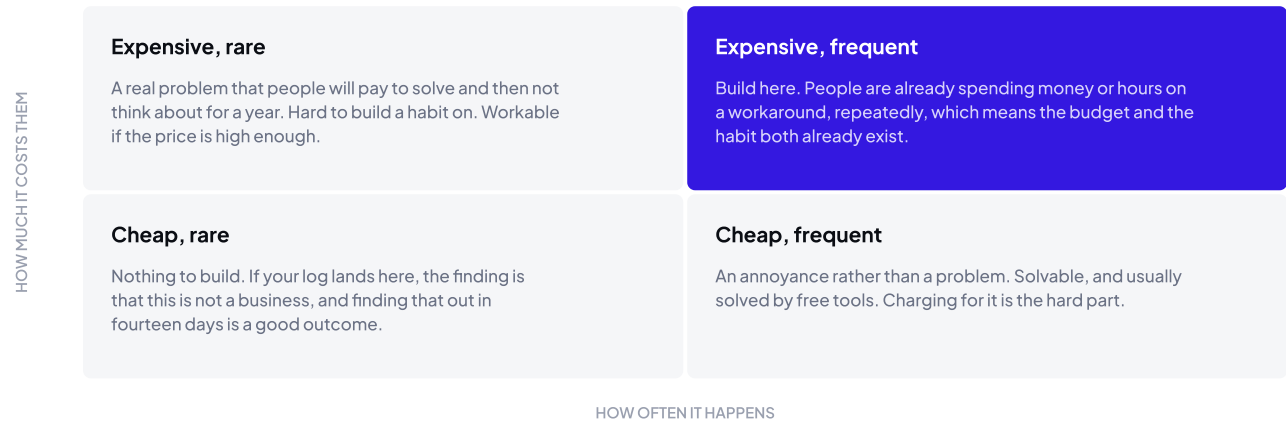
Quote

3. Date · Who · Unprompted? · Cost · Workaround

Quote

Two questions, asked of the whole log at once

Read the log in one sitting, at the end, with nothing else open. You are asking two things of it: how badly does this hurt, and how often does it happen. Those two answers place the problem, and the placement tells you whether to build anything at all.



Place the problem, then decide. Only one quadrant is worth a year of your life, and the log tells you which one you are in without you having to guess.

The three numbers that decide it

Unprompted mentions	Out of twenty. Under five and the problem is yours rather than theirs.
Median stated cost	In pounds or hours. If people cannot name a cost, they do not experience this as a problem.
People who asked you to follow up	Unprompted, at the end. This is the earliest honest demand signal you will get.

The decision

END OF DAY FOURTEEN

Write this before you talk to anyone about the result. A decision made out loud with a friend present is a decision made to sound reasonable.

Unprompted mentions, out of twenty

Median cost, as stated by them

Which quadrant the log puts you in

The problem statement, rewritten now that you have heard twenty people

Compare it to the one you started with. If nothing changed, you were not listening.

Continue, change the problem, or stop — and why

Stopping is a result

A log of twenty conversations that says nobody has this problem is worth more than a year spent building for nobody, and it is worth more in an application than a vague success. Programmes are unusually interested in founders who can show they changed their mind because of evidence.

The log from this toolkit is the input to **Toolkit 04 — The Demand Signal**, and the quotes are what fill the evidence section of **Toolkit 05 — The Application File**. Keep it.



StartPad tells you the truth about whether you are ready, gets you ready, and gives you the proof.

What it is

A founder-readiness platform for Egypt and the wider MENA region. It takes a young person who has an idea and no company, moves them through fifteen structured missions, and turns them into someone the ecosystem will take seriously — then issues verifiable proof of that.

It is not a course platform, not an education brand and not a youth club. Nothing here is graded. Every mission ends in an artefact you own.

Three moves, always in this order

TRUTH **Where you actually stand**

Measured against what programmes actually ask for, stated plainly, before any encouragement.

READINESS **Fifteen structured missions**

They close the specific gaps the assessment found, in the order that matters. A route, not a curriculum.

PROOF **A verifiable credential**

The ecosystem can check it without asking you. You apply with a file, not a hope.

On your idea

StartPad earns when a founder gets into somewhere — an accelerator, a programme, a room. Taking a founder's idea would end that. Work submitted to a mission is sealed and timestamped to the person who submitted it, and the seal is the product.

Nothing in this document asks you to give anything up to use it. It is yours to fill in, print, and hand to whoever needs to see it.

startpad.me

Start with the readiness assessment. It is free and it takes about twenty minutes.